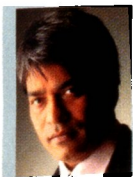


QED SHANKAR AJYAR

## UPA's Unclear Adventurism



That does read dyslexic. Perhaps it should read 'Nuclear Adventurism'. Sounds harsh? But that is because it is the truth. Last week, the UPA's man for all seasons, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee declared that "A minority government cannot, need not and should not sign a major agreement like this". It was virtually the announcement of the *uthaona* ceremony, the epitaph of the adventure that the Indo-US nuclear deal has been. Yes, the naïve votaries of the deal would like to see this as yet another round of semantics but the veteran who has seen the rise and fall of many regimes since the 1970s has told it like it is—that the UPA is incapable of pushing the deal. It could be argued that one can live with the deal as it is, just as it could be argued that one could live without the deal. This is not about the merit of the deal. It is about the merit of chasing the deal.

Since July 2005, this regime has been trying to live a lie, that it is in a position to cajole-coerce the Left and pass the deal.

Nothing could have been further from the truth because that would mean expecting the Reds to change their DNA. And say what you may about the Left, nobody can accuse them of infidelity to the cause of anti-imperialism.

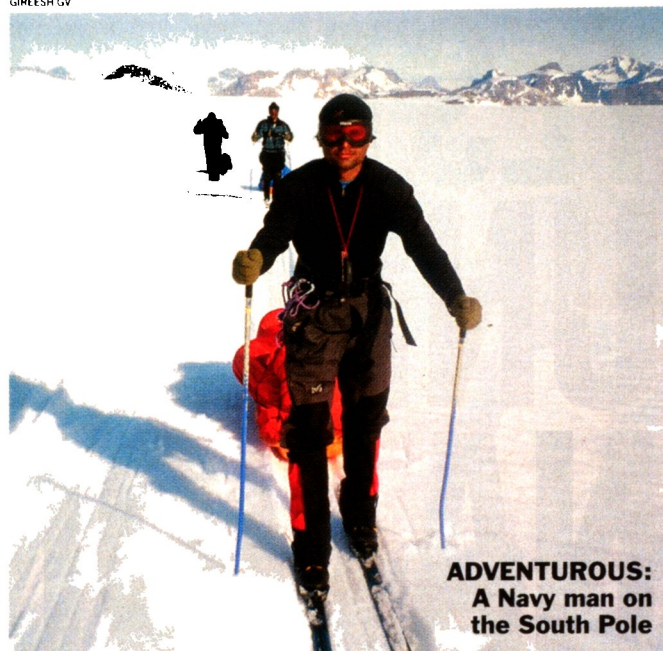
Sure the appeal to Bhishma Pitamah a.k.a. Atal Bihari

Vajpayee may have got the bite brigade excited but was it a smart tactic? Does the Congress believe it can ask and the BJP will deliver support for the deal? Assuming the BJP does deliver, would the allies who support this regime "to keep communal forces at bay" stay with them? Indeed does the Congress believe it can sup with the "devil" at home and the "Satan" abroad and still get Muslim votes just because it is spending Rs 500 crore more on them this year? Would there be anything left of the UPA? The votaries are clearly chasing a phantom.

Unlike corporate boardrooms where minority shareholder interests are at best a myth, in coalition politics, the smallest party is as powerful, if not more, than the largest party. The bill to please the PMK in the AUMS episode has proved this. Here, the Left with 60 MPs is the second largest shareholder of the UPA. Somehow this arithmetic seems to have escaped the CEO. The fact is that this regime has never been in any position to push the deal. And if this isn't adventurism, I wonder what is.



GIREESH GV



**ADVENTUROUS:**  
A Navy man on  
the South Pole

## Polar Express

**DELHI** Is adventure sports the newest frontier for healthy inter-service rivalry? The Indian Army stole a march over the navy when its yacht, *Trishna*, sailed around the world in 1987. The air force flew a microlite around the world last year. Not to be left behind, the navy, which sailed around the world only four years ago, is now seeking new frontiers for its adventure sportsmen. The problem is, there don't seem to be many left.

Climbing Mount Everest has long ceased to be a challenge and anyone with a lot of greenbacks can travel to both poles. The last remaining feat it seems is to enter the three poles club—Mount Everest is considered a third pole. The Indian Navy flagged off its team which is to become the first to go to all three poles—three of its members have already been to the South Pole and climbed the Mount Everest in the last two years. The

force will become the first organisation to conquer all three poles. The expedition hopes to plant the Indian flag and the naval ensign on the North Pole next month after a painful ski-traverse—10 team members will pull manual sleds across 130 km of frozen ice and brave winds of up to 80 kmph and temperatures 30 degrees below zero—something they did across Antarctica last year. Ski-traversing is only possible in winter when the pole freezes into one giant ice cap, yet it is considered physically the toughest means of getting to the pole. "Only 23 individuals have conquered all three poles," says team leader Commander Satyabrata Dam who along with two of his team mates will add three more to the tally. It is also an irony that a naval team will have conquered three land extremities—an army preserve. The tally may now be even.

by Sandeep Unnithan